

The Opportunity in Disconnection

On Keeping Halakha and Loving God

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Keeping halakha, in its lenient and its stringent points alike, is the cornerstone of Orthodox religious identity. One could argue that this choice stems from sociological motives: because of the formality and objectivity of halakha, it serves as a convenient, simple touchstone for sectarian distinction between one who "belongs to the covenant" and one who does not. Yet such an interpretation seems shallow, missing the deeper dimension of the central role halakha plays in defining a person's religiosity.

In our inner stance toward halakha we divide, broadly, into three types, which — by way of paraphrase — we may call "truth," "peace," and "judgment." The inner stance that stands at the summit is one of internal identification ("truth"). In this state a person keeps halakha out of enthusiasm, devotion and love of God. He channels his yearning for the divine and his desire to serve his Maker into the cast frameworks of halakhic action, and he refrains from what is forbidden out of a conscious, discerning moral recoil. He understands and identifies with the halakhic system as a whole, from its deep spiritual roots to its most minute details.

Against this elevated inner state, which for us often represents the summit of the religious type, stand two states that characterize the "middling" person. The first "middling" type relates to halakha as his taken-for-granted culture ("peace"). Halakha, even in its more exacting demands, does not constitute an existential burden for him — because he grew accustomed to this way of life from childhood. For such a person, halakhic activity demands no psychic effort and brings no spiritual tension — he lives it naturally, and for that reason is also free of intellectual, existential or moral inhibitions.

The second "middling" type is the one who keeps halakha out of "acceptance of judgment." Unlike the two types above, he lives in an inwardly dis-harmonious world: his relation to halakha is generally fraught with tension; he moves between identification and anger, between connection and distress; his decision to keep halakha arises out of inner ferment and conflict, and brings about the suppression and subjugation of other inner voices that rise within him; and so on.

As a community, I sense, we identify more with this third type. The culture in which we live and grow up is not identical to the traditional halakha-observant world — it contains, in mixed measure, many elements from different and contradictory worlds of values. Beyond that, in many of our homes halakha is not presented as holding supreme veto power; and even where it does hold such power in principle, there is not always a rigorous and comprehensive effort to clarify that halakhic law in all its scope. We find ourselves identifying more with the figure of the "penitent" (ba'al teshuva), who enters the depths of

his Judaism only after having come from other, varied worlds, and after having grown accustomed to norms different from the traditional or halakhic ones. For such a figure, entering the covenant of God — in the sense of deciding that Torah and halakha are the way of life — constitutes an inner move made out of deep, conscious choice. Accordingly, this decision will stand under repeated rational scrutiny and will be more open to the pricking of doubt. Even if it is a total decision that admits no retreat — as befits the nature of a covenant, which leaves no room for doubt regarding the general decision itself — the anguish, the wrestling and the ambivalent feelings born of it are not thereby sealed off. Every encounter a person has with a new halakhic provision that oppressively contradicts his old norms of existence gives rise to a certain inner resentment; and if that provision is also not accepted by the heart and by plain reason, this resentment turns into anger and rebellion, which then stand alongside religious feelings of submission and self-nullification — all of which together bring about an emotional mixture of helplessness and frustration.

Often the feeling is that our critical stance toward halakha is a defect, and that the naïve, traditional posture is more desirable before God, both because it brings about more actual observance of halakha (mainly as a result of the "penitent's" lack of familiarity with halakhic norms), and because it brings greater ease (mainly psychological, and at times also practical) in keeping halakha. This is a deep and complex issue, but since our purpose here focuses on the existential struggle of the third type, we will not dwell on the discussion of the "ideal" social culture. Whether or not this is God's will, the third type exists, and the tension between us and halakha is a fact that actually exists in our lives.

The peak of the crisis does not occur when there is an unfamiliar halakha that is hard to keep; a difficulty of that sort we manage to cope with, sometimes more and sometimes less successfully. The hardest feelings arise precisely when the identification of God's will with the particular halakhic detail seems to us absurd to the point of mockery and cheapening. When halakha branches out into the minutest details, or arrives at improbable (and oppressive) conclusions through a quasi-mathematical logic devoid of deep reason or plain sense, it is hard for us to see in it the absolute, supreme word of God. This is especially true regarding the pettier obligations — precisely these are the ones that make it hardest for us to grasp halakha as an expression of something sublime and deeply significant, even though their practical demand is lighter. We feel angry that halakha developed in its own unique internal language, without seeing the need to tie itself to worlds such as plain reason, historical circumstance, theological thought, or morality (or at least so it sometimes seems). As though it were not important for it to meet all the other criteria of God's will, but only to remain faithful to its own rhythm and its own strange (and infuriating) logic. And after all that, it comes and obligates us in the name of the word of God!

It seems that the central obstacle to our accepting this exactingness is theological — it is hard for us to picture the divine demand as descending to small, non-essential details. This theological conception sketches a God whose main "role" is in the realm of ideas, of supreme morality, of behavioral foundations and their principles, of life's basic experiences and their content — in short, only in great manifestations of spirit. When we encounter a

petty demand in the name of the word of God, and are asked to attribute to God an "interest" in tiny tasks devoid of any general moral significance, we recoil, and in some sense see in this a dimension of anthropomorphizing God. This recoil joins, of course, the simple difficulty of standing up to a strange, new halakhic demand.

These feelings, even if not entirely justified, testify to a crisis that must be resolved. I will therefore not judge these feelings here, for this is not the place for such judgment; instead I will try to present a solution that accepts, as its starting point, the existence of these feelings, and makes use precisely of the psychological difficulty they cause in order to deepen the connection with God.

Beyond the particular answers, each occupied in turn with defending and explaining halakha, its inner logic and the depth of truth it holds down to its minutest details, I think we cannot do without a comprehensive existential answer to this entire tension. The great question that this state of frustration and puzzlement raises is the question of why to keep halakha at all. Why define ourselves as absolutely obligated to a religious law of this kind, even where there are places we feel and think that it does not express the will of God, or any value at all? Why subordinate our lives, our religiosity and our deep will to serve God, to the rigid and improbable framework of halakha?

In my view, a person who avoids keeping halakhot that do not seem right to him actually distances himself from the great opportunity of forging a true covenant with the Holy One. He does not correctly understand the relationship that is meant to form between a person and his God, and places God too far removed from the fabric of everyday life. In order to illustrate the essence of the matter we must follow our prophets and sages, and grasp the bond between a man and a woman as an image for the bond between us and the Holy One.

When a couple marry, they decide to forge a covenant that binds them together always, in a bond that is obligating, mutual and demanding. True, one marries when one loves, and romantic ardor is the sap that animates the marriage and grants it its happiness and the foundation of pleasure within it. But from the moment the marriage covenant is forged, the couple no longer choose; they are obligated to one another, and are called upon to live with one another — even when it is burdensome, even when it is unromantic, even when they are tired or irritable, and even when the other has his or her "quirks." A person who enters a covenant is a person who has brought into his world a binding element of supreme validity, which overrides his momentary will. In this self-transcendence, in this departure from the banality that exists in a life confined to egocentric or materialistic wants, a person acquires meaning and content for his life and rescues himself from emptiness.

The experience of marriage with the Holy One does not pass only through experiences of depth or through ecstatic emotional outbursts; it is a way of life in which we must live together with the Holy One. Every minor halakha is a profound test within this relationship of ours with the Holy One, and we are called upon to meet it even when we are not stirred and in love, and even when we are irritated by the whole matter. This is the only way to keep a covenant.

If we decide that only the full, heroic, sublime and soul-elevating experience is an experience bound up with divine presence, we sentence ourselves to a life that is in practice more distant from God. The soul cannot remain in the tension and sublimity of the fully glorious religious experience; its nature is to live also feelings that are more mundane, lower, of a fainter vitality and color. This resembles the experience of the "spark" of romantic falling-in-love — the kind that insists that all matters of the couple's bond be carried out only from the supreme feeling of love as burning coals, and does not allow itself an ordinary, this-worldly coupledness, a coupledness realized over the course of an entire life. Therefore, we must determine that our religiosity is founded upon an experience of dialogue and of standing as a couple before God from whatever state or place we find ourselves in — even out of laziness or gloom, even out of apathy and lack of identification, even out of bitterness and even out of irritation and anger. From wherever we are, we shall stand before God and carry out His requests, in the submission of love. Only in this way does one attain a conscious presence of the love of God in life.

One who has given up accepting the yoke of halakha, and has permitted himself to be the one who decides which halakha is so exceptionally irritating and foolish that he is unwilling to keep it, has in effect removed the Holy One from the close, "domestic" encounter with Him. The moment that, by his feelings, there is supposedly a limit to what the Holy One may demand, he misses out on true marriage with Him. His religiosity becomes conditional on his feelings, and it is not a mature coupledness — it is not a "covenant." Only one who decides to trust in halakha can attain a mature, deep and lasting bond of love with God.

[Appendix for Sukkot:]

On the festival of Sukkot we emphasize and renew precisely this facet of our relationship with the Holy One. The sukkah is our wedding canopy with the Holy One; it is our shared home. The basic experience is that a person enters the sukkah, and God hovers over him in His Shekhinah. But the sukkah expresses not only an experience of sublime, exhilarating union, but also the constant and difficult demand to live together with God in a home, exactly as a married couple. The commandment of the festival is to dwell in the sukkah for seven days, and to make the sukkah our home in every sense, to the point that we are called upon to perform even the most basic and banal actions of our existence in the sukkah. The sense of burden present in keeping the laws of the festival is itself the unique experience of the festival, of forging a covenant and building a home with God. In this sense, Sukkot, more than all the other festivals, faithfully expresses the normal experience of existence that we, as servants of God, ought to have. Our very lives are a home that we build together with God, and He dwells within them and sets within them both His demands, on the one hand, and His goodness and lovingkindness, on the other. This is the only way of life in which we are truly bound together in deep love with God, and in which we have the option to delight in Him with the supreme pleasure of devotion — "I delighted to sit in his shade, and his fruit was sweet to my taste."